BACK TO BASE



Gujarat Congress president **Shaktisinh Gohil's** resignation after the party lost the assembly bypolls for two seats was on the anvil following an equally abysmal performance in the municipality polls in February this year. Gohil's Rajya Sabha term ends in 2026, which allows him the opportunity to try his luck in electoral politics in the 2027 state assembly election or make a move to the party headquarters in Delhi. He's aiming for the latter, it is reliably learnt.

Black Magic



The pursuit of power takes one down some strange dark alleys. Maharashtra minister **Bharat Gogawale** of the Shiv Sena (Eknath Shinde faction) has been accused of performing Aghori rituals to get the post of Raigad district's guardian minister. Suraj Chavan, a spokesperson of Mahayuti ally Nationalist Congress Party, shared a video of him with Aghori sadhus. Gogawale is locked in a fierce contest with NCP's Aditi Tatkare for the post. Meanwhile, Shiv Sena UBT's Bhaskar Jadhav and Shinde Sena's Ramdas Kadam are also accusing each other of using black magic to harm the other. Guess the dark clouds hovering over Mumbai are affecting its netas too.

REBELS AND REMINDERS





July marks five years since Sachin Pilot's alleged rebellion, and Rajasthan ex-CM **Ashok Gehlot** isn't ready to lay the matter to rest. He recalled how he had "saved" his Congress government from a "BJP-backed, money-powered plot". Gehlot also took a jab at current CM **Bhajan Lal Sharma**. "The BJP chose a first-time MLA as CM, but he needs to connect with the people and workers," the veteran leader said. Sharma fired back, claiming his 18-month report card outshines Gehlot's. "In three months, 5,000 villages will be poverty-free. Modi erases poverty, Congress only talks," he declared.

Kaushik Deka with Amitabh Srivastava, Jumana Shah, Dhaval S. Kulkarni and Rohit Parihar

ECO WATCH

By **Rahul Noronha and Sonali Acharjee**

THE TIGER IN THE ROOM



Recognising that wildlife conservation cannot be restricted to 'protected areas' (PAs), the Centre has sanctioned a project to mitigate man-tiger conflict in 80 most-affected forest divisions across 10 states. Funded by the Compensatory Afforestation Fund Management and Planning Authority (Rs 88 crore for 2025-27), the project will utilise technology to monitor tigers and their prey base, and also involve civil society to prevent man-animal conflict. The 2022 tiger census says that around a third of India's 3,682 tigers live outside the PAs (national parks and sanctuaries). Some 400 people were killed by the big cats between 2020 and 2024. Conflict hotspots are mostly in UP, MP, Maharashtra, Kerala and Uttarakhand.

A SPIDERY COMEBACK

Indian arachnophiles have four reasons to celebrate. Four new spider species were recorded in the country in June, and there has been first sightings of two species. A new species, *Psechrus chizami*, was discovered in the forests of Nagaland; *Psechrus nathanael* was found in Meghalaya; and *Pidelaxia falciformis sp. nov.* and *Epidelaxia palustris sp. nov.* in Kerala. In addition, scientists from the Zoological Survey of India also made the first official sightings of *Pardosa tuberosa* and *Thiania abdominalis* in Meghalaya. The discoveries in Kerala are the first time the genus Epidelaxia has been found in any other country outside of Sri Lanka. The research, which involved the University of Kerala, was published in *Zootaxa*, a peer-reviewed journal.

